

THE EVOLUTION OF TROLLS

PEOPLE HAVE BEEN WRITING ABOUT THIS CREATURE CALLED THE INTERNET TROLL FOR SOME TIME NOW, MOSTLY UNFAVOURABLY, LIKENING THEM TO TERRIBLE MUTATIONS THAT WE HOPE WILL DIE OUT. SHOULD THEY?

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ILLUSTRATION:
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Every one of you has already encountered an internet troll. Even if you've not been the target of a troll attack, and don't even know what a troll is, you've certainly seen someone on social media who had to deal with them. If you've ever read the comments of a popular video on YouTube, or if you've read comments on popular Facebook posts, you know that there are some people out there who deliberately like to stir things up and cause debates to get heated, and topic of discussions to get derailed.

Those of you who have lived a life before the internet will know that there always were some people who were like this. Some of us would have had friends (or classmates) who would fit this description of a "trouble-maker. However, is that really the definition of the word "troll"?

WHAT IS A TROLL?

There are several different definitions to be found on the popular site urbandictionary.com, and to be honest, we think all of them kind of fit. Here are a few:

"One who posts a deliberately provocative message to a newsgroup or message board with the intention of causing maximum disruption and argument."

Or

"One who purposely and deliberately (that purpose usually being self-amusement) starts an argument in a manner which attacks others on a forum without in any way listening to the arguments proposed by his or her peers. He will spark off such an argument

via the use of ad hominem attacks (i.e. "you're nothing but a fanboy" is a popular phrase) with no substance or relevance to back them up as well as straw-man arguments, which he uses to simply avoid addressing the essence of the issue."

Or

"An angry monster who lives under a bridge, eats goats, and vents his rage on YouTube."

There are many more interesting takes on the definition, but we have a word limit to adhere to.

Today, it seems like the word troll is used by people to describe someone on the internet (real or anonymous) who seems to be deliberately trying to irritate people (others or yourself), in order to:

- Just piss them (or you) off
- Derailed an otherwise serious discussion
- Spread lies and confusion for fun

WHY?

Ah. Now that's the billion dollar question. There have been many explanations put forth on the internet for why trolls are the way they are, and apparently some of them have been by the trolls themselves...

Everything from small-penis-syn-drome to mental disorders, and narcissism to sadism, almost everything that's wrong with the world can be blamed on internet trolls. To be honest, if you've ever been targeted by trolls, you know for a fact that you have caught yourself wishing that the troll's house would collapse in the middle of a family reunion, just so that the genetic lineage of the a\$\$hole is wiped

clean. That's just rage speaking, however, and you know that there are times trolls can be fun too. This is especially true when you read some of the comments on popular videos – it's where the term "comment gold" comes from. There are times when trolls can be just plain hilarious.

We've all had those friends who, during diwali, put rockets into bottles and fire them sideways (parallel to the street), to make crowds of people jump and dive and do crazy things to get out of the firecracker's trajectory. Do they know it's dangerous? Sure. Do they care? Heck no! We think it's safe to assume that you certainly did enjoy seeing rockets fizz about everywhere, even though you had to duck or jump out of the way of a few yourself. It certainly got your heart pounding faster, and seemed very exciting. Would you do that yourself? (Assuming, of course, that you weren't the one who did such things). Probably not. There is, then, a case to be made for trolls certainly being exciting, or at least, entertaining.

TROLLING REDEFINED?

So do we have to stick with this assumption of being an internet "troll"? Was there no such thing as a troll in the pre-internet days? We have to concede that the usage of the word itself has only skyrocketed in internet times, and so, the now traditional usage of the word itself really does mean "internet troll". Strictly speaking, a "troll", in 2016 language, really is someone on the internet who does a wide range of things, which generally involve getting some people angry – the angrier the better, for the troll.